As the traditional custodians of Sikh faith and politics see their influence recede, some old challengers resurface along with the rise of new contenders

## OLD CHALLENGERS



### ↘ HARPAL SINGH CHEEMA

**Who is he:** The chief of Dal Khalsa, a pro-Khalistan outfit founded by Gajinder Singh (who had hijacked an Indian Airlines flight in 1981)

**Panthic push:** Both Cheema and Gajinder, who is holed up in Pakistan, have a significant hold on Sikh preachers globally and keep accusing the Indian and Punjab government of not doing enough for the community



### ↘ GURDEEP SINGH BATHINDA

**Who is he:** A former editor of pro-panthic newspaper *Aj Di Awaz*, he is a prominent face of the United Akali Dal

**Panthic push:** He is seen as a key constituent of the intellectual vanguard that has shaped the panthic movement in the past 15 years



### ↘ SIMRANJIT SINGH MANN

**Who is he:** A pro-Khalistan leader and chief of SAD (Amritsar), he represents Sangrur in the Lok Sabha

**Panthic push:** Bounced back in electoral politics after two decades. He's among the few Akali leaders who didn't abandon the separatist line and remained a rallying point for radicals



### ↘ GURCHARAN SINGH HAWARA

**Who is he:** Father of Jagtar Hawara, who was convicted in Punjab CM Beant Singh's assassination. The Qaumi Insaf Morcha convenor wants the release of all 'Bandi Singhs'

**Panthic push:** Backed by both panthic leaders and several Left organisations. In Nov. 2016, radical Sikh outfits had declared his son, who is lodged in Tihar Jail, the parallel jathedar of Akal Takht



### ↘ AMRITPAL SINGH SANDHU

**Who is he:** A transporter-turned-Sikh activist, he took over the reins of socio-religious group Waris Punjab De after returning from Dubai last year

**Panthic push:** With looks and histrionics similar to slain terrorist and radical icon Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale, he has positioned himself as a new fulcrum for the panthic cause

**↘ AN ALL INDIA SIKH GURDWARA ACT** to bring about a reunited SGPC, and free Sikh institutions from government control. Haryana has constituted its own gurdwara panel

**↘ CHANDIGARH'S TRANSFER TO PUNJAB** and termination of the Sutlej-Yamuna Link (SYL) Canal project, two key sticking points with Haryana and the Centre

**↘ BETTER REPRESENTATION FOR SIKHS** in the higher echelons of judiciary, bureaucracy, defence and other security forces besides academia

Sr pretty much captured the panthic space—most hardliners like Simranjit Mann or Gurcharan Tohra were marginalised. From those commanding heights, the roots of the present decline were sown as the SAD declared itself a secular, pan-Punjab party, allied with the BJP and even fielded Hindu candidates for assembly polls. In 2019, the Badals presided over an even steeper fall with their stance on Article 370 and the Citizenship Amendment Act, going against the grain of federalism that has always marked Sikh politics. And even if it broke with the BJP on the farm laws, the long association cost it dearly and added to its image of being far removed from its panthic Jat Sikh base. The accusations of outright mismanagement during the 2015 incidents of sacrilege of Sikh scriptures, when it was in power, crowned that sense of apathy.

Last year's polls put only three SAD faces in the assembly, none with a panthic background. The party, whose vote share usually ranges between the mid-30s and mid-40s, managed only 18-odd per cent. In the subsequent bypoll for the Sangrur Lok Sabha seat, it was the old radical Simranjit Singh Mann who won; the Badal faction attempted to win back radical sympathies by fielding Kamaldeep Kaur Rajoana, the sister of Balwant Rajoana, who was convicted in the Beant Singh assassination, but she came a poor fifth.

## FILLING A VACUUM

As former parliamentarian Tarlochan Singh puts it, Punjab feels the lack of a genuine Sikh leader—social, religious or political—profoundly. He also points to other absences, asking why the apex court, the armed forces brass or top bureaucracy lack Sikh faces.

It is in this vacuum that the new panthic faces are finding a following. Most analyses of the dramatic rise of AAP ascribe it to the feelings of anger against the established bodies, primarily the Sikh ones, that were perceived to have fallen into lethargy. Now Mann's regime is also being accused, even by its own MLAs, of not following up on the 2015 incidents or the subsequent